Given an iron box, known to contain wealth, and to contain dynamite, arranged to explode when the key is used to unlock it – what would any sane man do? What would he advise?

About the author:



Silas Weir Mitchell (1829-1914) was a neurologist by profession. He was among the famous physicians of his time and a prolific writer of both scientific and literary works. He was born in Philadelphia, studied at the University of Pennsylvania and received the degree of M.D. in 1850. He is considered the father of neurology as well as a pioneer in scientific medicine. He published more than 25 literary titles and his medical experiences and background enabled him to write historical fiction with much psychological insight. Many honorary degrees were conferred upon him by several Universities at home and abroad. The American Academy of Neurology award for young researchers is named after him.

Glossary

ingenious (adj.) - clever, original and inventive

mania (n) - an extensive, persistent desire, an obsession

malicious (adj.) - spiteful, intended to harm or upset someone

queer (adj.) - strange, odd

appalled (adj.) - horrified, shocked

oddity (n) - the quality being strange or peculiar

closet (n) - cupboard

incredible (adj.) - impossible to believe

contrive (v) - cook up, hatch a plan by deliberate use of skills

despotic (adj.) - tyrannical, autocratic

avarice (n) - extreme greed for wealth

jest (n) - a joke

vivisection (n) - a surgery conducted on a living organism for experimental purposes.

A. Read the given lines carefully and identify the character / speaker:

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1. I suppose you think me queer. I will explain.
2. Don't come back. It won't hasten things.
3. He thought it simply a cruel jest.
4. He did not desire to do so.
5. He would think it over and come back later.

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